

Q How quickly will I be given a C-section if it is decided during labor that I need one?

That depends on the level of emergency for your C-section. The procedure will be performed as quickly as the clinical need, and your baby could be delivered within 30 minutes or up to 75 minutes of a C-section being decided upon. Most hospitals use a two-level grading system. If either you or your baby is considered to be in danger, you'll have a Category 1 C-section, done as speedily as possible. When neither you nor your baby is in a life-threatening situation (for example, if you're too tired to keep going, or if your baby is awkwardly positioned), your C-section will be a Category 2 and there will be a little more time to prepare for surgery.

Q How is the placenta delivered when I've had a C-section? Will it have to be cut away from my uterus lining?

No, once your baby is out, your doctor will deliver the placenta in a very similar way that he or she would do if it had been a vaginal birth. Your doctor will gently pull on the umbilical cord to separate the placenta fully and draw it out through the incision in your abdomen. Once the entire placenta and the membranes have been removed from your uterus, your doctor can begin to put everything back into place in your abdomen to get you ready to be stitched up.

Q Will I be able to go right to a postpartum ward with my baby after the surgery?

Usually you will spend a few hours in a recovery room adjacent to the operating room, with your baby if possible. The doctor or nurse will check your blood pressure and heart rate regularly, and make sure you have no signs of complications relating to the surgery. You will be given some pain medication and your doctor will make sure you feel able to eat and drink normally. If all is well and you are awake and alert, you can usually then move onto the postpartum ward.

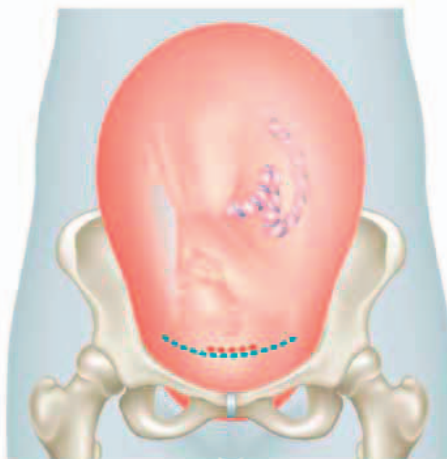
Q What will happen during the cesarean section?

After giving the anesthetic, the anesthesiologist will make sure you cannot feel anything. You may feel some pushing and pulling, but it should not be painful.

You will have a catheter tube inserted through your urethra to drain your bladder during the surgery and once your abdomen is swabbed with antiseptic solution the surgery can begin. An incision is made just below the top of your pubic hair. The obstetrician divides the layers of fat and fibrous muscle tissue before making an incision in the lower part of the uterus. If the membranes surrounding your baby have not ruptured, this will be done now. Whatever part of your baby's body is below the incision will be delivered first. Your

baby is normally delivered in the first ten minutes once surgery is underway. After the delivery, the cord is clamped and your baby can be handed to you for her first embrace.

The low horizontal incision (known as transverse) made in your abdomen is usually 6–8 in (15–20 cm) long—this is the cut seen on your skin. It leaves a modest scar that fades over time. The incision made in the uterus underneath is only 2¼–2¾ in (5–7 cm) long, to keep scarring on your uterus to a minimum. This helps to reduce the risk of gynecological problems later and increases your chance of having a safe vaginal birth if you go on to have another pregnancy. In unusual and very specific circumstances, a vertical (longitudinal) cut may be done. Try not to worry about scarring too much—it is just one of many changes that will take place in your body.



KEY

- 2¼–2¾ in (5–7 cm) incision in uterus
- 6–8 in (15–20 cm) incision in abdomen

Transverse incision This is the most common incision and is associated with fewer risks and a better chance of subsequent vaginal births. It leaves a discreet scar along your bikini line.

Q How soon will I be able to leave the hospital? Will I have to go back to have stitches out?

You can usually leave the hospital between three and four days after your C-section.

Sometimes you can leave as quickly as 24 hours later (your catheter will come out around 12 hours after the surgery), if your baby is well and you have made a fast initial recovery. It's very unlikely you will need to go back to the hospital to have stitches taken out. The stitches in your uterus will be dissolvable. You may also have dissolvable stitches at your abdominal incision. If you have surgical sutures or staples in your abdomen, these will be removed around five days after the surgery. This may be done in the hospital if you are there, or your doctor can

remove them if you have gone home. If you had a longitudinal (vertical) incision, you may need to have your stitches in for a little longer.

Q How quickly can I get out of bed and resume normal activities?

You'll be encouraged to walk around and eat and drink normally as soon as possible after your C-section, as long as the anesthesia has worn off and you aren't feeling dizzy or unwell. Movement will also decrease your chances of blood clots (an injection to prevent thrombosis is often given as well). Activities such as lifting and driving will take longer. See page 260 for some of the commonly asked questions about recovering from a cesarean section.